Iranian government as well as the leader Khomeini, but the agent who made it possible quietly disappeared for another operation in another difficult terrain.'

Vipul, who had sort of turned into a recluse after the sixteen-month-long operation in a hostile territory, had an opportunity to meet Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi along with G.C. Saxena.

'Gandhi asked Garry in a whisper whether he could give Vipul a Padma Bhushan award. The chief smiled and said, 'No sir. The reward for a spy is the success of the operation. He doesn't need any other decoration,' Anil Prasad told me later, when he recounted the various methods Vipul had used to turn a complete failure into a success. Those details, though, are classified as top secret and will remain buried in the R&AW vault for ages to come.

EPILOGUE

In an age when digital threats are as dangerous as non-state fanatics, intelligence officers often wonder: How far should spy operations go to eliminate threats to national security? They also ask this question: Is traditional spy tradecraft in which human intelligence (HUMINT) is tasked with recruiting and running spies in enemy countries still relevant in this age of electronic surveillance? Could data accessed via cyber espionage replace a good spy behind the enemy lines?

Today's debates on intelligence gaps and shortcomings at the National Security Council meetings in Delhi compare the harvests produced by men and machines, with more and more emphasis on eyes in the sky. But logically, such differentiation is treacherous. Threats faced by the country are multidimensional